DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Does God Punish Out of Love?

Daat Tevunot §154-156

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §154-156
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 17 July 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Mishpat comes from love

We are in the middle of §154, in the part of Section 7 that shows how Hashem's mishpat comes from His love. The Rabbi repeated the theme of these weeks: we tend to think of mishpat as negative, but it is essentially positive. "Mishpat essentially means consequence," for good and for bad. Being rewarded is mishpat too.

The Ramhal says that from Hashem's love come three things:

1. **Kindness:** when we do good, He wants to give us great reward.
2. **Chastisement:** from that same love, when we do wrong He disciplines us.
3. **The middle path of mercy:** even when He disciplines, it is diluted with love. "The left hand pushes away and the right draws near."

Why Moshe waited to rebuke

The Rabbi tied this to the parashah of that week. The book of Devarim, which was beginning that Shabbat, is mostly Moshe's rebuke of the people. Why did he wait until the end of his life? The Midrash explains that most people who tell you off do so because you bother them, not because they care about you. Even when someone means well, the listener may not believe it. So Moshe waited until he was about to die, to show: "I have nothing to gain. I have no axe to grind. I want the best for you."

Two ways love shapes judgment

Looking more closely, the Ramhal finds two things in this love:

- When Hashem must chastise, the love sweetens the judgment so that it does not destroy us, and He is easily appeased.
- Sometimes, out of love, He overrides everything and acts with pure kindness, ignoring the scales.

The Rabbi gave his familiar example of a child who runs into the road. A parent who screams because he got a fright is venting his own frustration. That is not rebuke and not mishpat. A loving parent disciplines with one hand and draws the child close with the other. But

sometimes the child looks up and says "I'm so sorry", and the parent says, "Fine, I don't need to do anything to you, because you're just too cute."

He contrasted three kinds of parents. One disciplines out of love. One does nothing because he does not care, and that is lack of love, the hester we learned about earlier in the section ("if another child runs into the road, it's not your child"). And one overlooks the offence because he loves the child too much. That last one is a conscious decision to override, which is the opposite of indifference.

The 13 attributes and Rosh Hashanah

This override is the power of the 13 attributes of mercy: "I will be gracious to whom I will be gracious," even when the person does not deserve it. The Rabbi explained why Rosh Hashanah comes before Yom Kippur. Surely our sins should be cleared first and then we should be judged? No. If you can get Hashem to override the whole system, you do not need to worry about the details. On Rosh Hashanah He rises from the throne of justice and sits on the throne of mercy. The Midrash reads "Hashem passed before him" as Hashem passing before Moshe with these attributes, so that the "face of anger" passes away. The shofar has the same power.

Not a natural necessity

The Ramhal adds a subtle point. For a human parent, discipline follows from love more or less automatically. Hashem is not bound by anything. That mishpat flows from His love is something He willed, not a natural law that binds Him.

Principles, not details

All of this has many details. Hashem first set the general principles of His consequences and then assessed each person and each case. The Rabbi said that if one thing stays with us from the Ramhal, it is how much he loves principles: "at least ten times he said in this book, I can't give you all the details, but I'll give you the principles." Prophets were sometimes shown some of the details. To know them all would be to be God Himself, as the Rabbi quoted from Rav Saadiah Gaon: "If I knew Him, I would be Him."

When bad things happen

A participant asked how this helps the individual, who usually does not know why he is suffering. The Rabbi said that something bad may be entirely random, because Hashem may not be focused on you: "don't overrate yourself." But the Gemara says that a person who sees suffering come upon him should examine his deeds, and if he finds nothing, he should attribute it to neglect of Torah study. "Study, study, study." He agreed that it is good practice to think this way, because it means you have a relationship with Hashem.

Hashem's assessment never stops. It accounts for every "cog" in the system, every rise and fall and every period.

Looking ahead

In §155-156 the Ramhal says there is no end to wisdom, quoting Kohelet: "I said, I will be wise, but it was far from me." Footnote 99 sums up the section so far. We have seen the five phases of judgment, how emanations make creatures more physical or more spiritual, as with Shabbat and Yom Tov, and how judgment comes from love. All of it is only from the point of view of the effect on us, because God's essence is beyond our grasp. That will be the subject of the final part.

Summary

- From Hashem's love come kindness, chastisement, and mercy that softens the chastisement.
- Moshe rebuked Israel just before his death so they would know it came from love alone.
- Love can also override judgment altogether. This is the power of the 13 attributes and of Rosh Hashanah, and it is the opposite of indifference.
- Hashem is not bound by His love. That mishpat flows from it is His will.
- When suffering comes, examine your deeds, and if nothing is found, strengthen your Torah study.

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